among the species endangered as a result.

Loss of coral reefs

Coral reefs are important ecoregions and yet are especially endangered. They support about 25 percent of the planet's marine species, and are also nurseries for billions of fish. Three-quarters of the world's reefs are under threat, and about a quarter of them are likely damaged beyond repair.

One of the greatest threats to coral reefs is climate change, which is leading to warmer waters. If the water gets too hot, corals expel the zooxanthellae (algae) that live in their tissues. This causes the coral to turn white, and is known as "coral bleaching." While the bleaching does not kill corals, it leaves them vulnerable and can ultimately lead to their death.

In addition, coral reefs are being destroyed by overfishing, and by harmful practices such as cyanide and blast fishing, and bottom trawling. Sediment resulting from coastal development blocks the sunlight that reefs need. Chemical pollution, coral mining, and careless tourism all add to the burden on this highly sensitive habitat.

Wide-ranging impacts

All over the world, diverse natural habitats are critically threatened by human activity. Tropical deciduous dry forest is easier to clear than rainforest, and on Madagascar, where dry forest was widespread, the populations of 90 percent of dry forest tree species are decreasing. At one time, tallgrass prairie stretched across the US Midwest, but less than 4 percent of it is left: the rest has been converted to farmland. Many wetlands have been drained for agriculture or urban development; others are irreversibly damaged by pollution. Nutrient runoff from agricultural fertilizers has spoiled many lakes and rivers. In many countries, intertidal zones have been destroyed by the building of ports. Deforestation, coastal